CRIMINAL BLUNDER 5

State of apathy

Clearly cornered, West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee's response did not paint her in a flattering light. Her government's decision to not accept Ghosh's resignation and instead transfer him as principal of another prominent state-run hospital was in itself confounding. The heavy-handed response to the protests—by the doctors, sections of civil society, general public, members of the film and theatre industry—has also drawn flak. On August 16, 42 doctors were transferred through a notification because they had taken part in the protests (the order was revoked by the evening). The next day, police commissioner Vineet Goyal imposed a section of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023 (formerly Sec. 144 of the CrPC) near the hospital premises, reportedly as an attempt to prevent protesters from gathering there. On August 18, a similar day-long order was imposed near the Yuva Bharati Stadium in Salt Lake City to stop the supporters of football clubs Mohun Bagan, East Bengal and Mohammedan Sporting from organising a protest around the stadium. The police had already cancelled a derby match between East Bengal and Mohun Bagan. The police has been also issuing notices to social media users, accusing them of spreading misinformation. They have also been summoning people who had participated in the rallies.



OUTRAGED CM Mamata at a protest rally in Kolkata, Aug. 16

AFP

↘ CM Mamata on the defensive, no strict action taken

↘ The state government's disproportionate response to the public protests draws flak

And though Mamata herself offered to transfer the case to the CBI and even took out a rally, her blaming the BJP and the Left for the vandalism on August 14 has backfired. Of the 32 people arrested so far, many were found to have oblique links with Trinamool Congress leaders.

Pulling up the state administration for the failure at multiple levels, the SC has come down heavily on the state administration, asking questions about the lax security at the hospital, Ghosh's transfer and the police paralysis as hoodlums ran amok at the RG Kar Hospital.

CRIMINAL BLUNDER 6

Fact vs social media fiction

First, there were the gruesome details about the rape and murder, not all of which were backed up by evidence. Rumours were flying around that it was a gang rape (not the work of an individual), that the victim's pelvic girdle had been crushed, there was broken glass in her eye, 150 gm of semen found inside her body.... Then, it was said that the four doctors she had dinner with had something to do with the crime, their names and pictures were put out on social media. One of them was even alleged to be the son of a TMC leader, all of which later proved untrue.

↘ Social media platforms host unsubstantiated rumours, wild theories, photographs and name of the victim and her colleagues

As for the girl's injuries, the autopsy report lists multiple abrasions on the victim's body parts but makes no mention of any broken bones. Meanwhile, the name, pictures and video clippings of the victim also began doing the rounds on several e-platforms. Visuals of the victim's mutilated face and half-clad body went viral too, fuelling the protest and rage.

It was eventually left to the Supreme Court to quell the madness as it directed all social media platforms to take down the name and all images of the victim. Even so, online searches for the victim's name, pictures and even videos of the rape continue.